

This school and its students are constantly battling a negative reputation. The second thing that auto-fills when you google “Gage Park High School” is “deaths.” According to [USNews.com](https://www.usnews.com), the school has a 97 percent “economically disadvantaged” population, as they so euphemistically put it. Jessica Aceves, a senior learning program coordinator for Build On, a nonprofit that runs after-school programs in Chicago, said that in 2016, 25 percent of students there went on to college. Gage Park has a 40.3 percent graduation rate, 25.1 percent lower than the Chicago public schools average of 65.4 percent. Most of the houses surrounding the school have wood boarding up the windows.

The young women I interviewed at Gage Park were low income and nonwhite. They were thoughtful and funny. They’ve seen the mistakes their parents and older siblings have made and don’t want to fall into the same traps. They’re worried about loans, debt, and getting a good job.

Jasmine wants to be a photographer. College, for her, wouldn’t be about education but about making connections. Instead of attending, she thinks she could network around Chicago or make a name for herself on social media. (At the end of the interview, she gave me her Instagram handle, and because I appreciated the hustle, I followed her.)

Of all the students I talked to, Jasmine’s classmate Marina will be spending the most money on college, attending a private university. She guessed it’ll run her \$46,000.

“For what? A piece of paper?” Jasmine cut in, shaking her head in disapproval. (I asked Jasmine if she wanted to write this book instead. She declined.)

Marina said she has some savings from her job at Chipotle and thinks her parents might kick in some money, but maybe not. A sibling may have ruined that for the both of them by making their parents pay for school, which they eventually dropped out of. Marina disdainfully reports that her sibling lives at home and racks up credit card debt.

Dry, whip-smart Cristina doesn’t know what she wants to do with her life yet—but she does know that college, because she doesn’t have specific major in mind, isn’t for her. She’s jaded. She sees colleges as businesses she wants to opt out of.